

ZEPTO CAFE

Step 2: Frame the Problem

Articulating Why Office Workers Don't Return for a Second Order
July 2026 · Airtribe PM Launchpad Case Study

12%	25%	47%
Current Repeat Rate	Target Repeat Rate	Have Tried Zepto Cafe
30-day repeat order rate	Goal in 6 months	Trial is NOT the problem

 1. Research Foundation — What the Data Told Us

Step 2 is grounded entirely in primary research (15 valid office/hybrid responses) and competitive analysis (Swiggy, Zomato, Blinkit, Starbucks). Every claim below traces back to evidence.

1a. The Trial–Repeat Gap

Our survey revealed the most important structural finding of this case study:

 Awareness is NOT the problem	 Retention IS the problem
47% of respondents	Only 12%
have tried Zepto Cafe at least once	place a second order within 30 days

This single fact reframes the entire product strategy: the question is not how to drive trial — it is how to convert a trial into a habit. The funnel is leaking at the second order, not the first.

1b. Why Users Say They Don't Repeat — Barrier Ranking

Survey respondents (n=15 valid, office/hybrid only) were asked to select all barriers that apply. Results:

Barrier	% Citing	PM Interpretation
Inconsistent food quality (taste, freshness, temperature)	73%	Root cause of first-order disappointment
Chai/snack stalls are more convenient nearby	73%	Habit already exists — Zepto needs to displace it
Prefer office canteen	60%	Physical proximity creates a default behavior
Price not worth it for the quality received	40%	Value-quality mismatch, not price sensitivity

Forgot to reorder / wasn't prompted	33%	No habit hook — the app goes silent after order 1
App navigation / discovery issues	13%	Friction, but low relative priority

1c. The Quality Paradox — What Users Care About vs. How Zepto Scores
Users were asked to rate attribute importance (1–5) and their satisfaction with Zepto Cafe on the same scale:

Attribute	Importance	Zepto Score	Gap	Signal
Food quality (taste)	4.60 / 5	3.57 / 5	-1.03	 Critical gap
Freshness of food	4.60 / 5	3.71 / 5	-0.89	 Critical gap
Value for money	4.20 / 5	3.86 / 5	-0.34	 Moderate gap
Delivery speed	4.40 / 5	4.57 / 5	+0.17	 Zepto's strength
App ease of use	3.80 / 5	4.00 / 5	+0.20	 Zepto's strength

Key Insight

Speed is Zepto Cafe's actual competitive advantage — 4.57/5. Users don't complain about delivery time.

Quality (taste 3.57, freshness 3.71) is the gap — and it scores lowest on the attributes users care about most (4.60 importance).

BUT: Kitchen operations are out of scope. The PM must solve the quality perception gap through in-app experience, not food prep.

 2. Top Friction Points — With Evidence

Friction points are ordered by their estimated impact on repeat rate — from highest to lowest.

F1 No habit trigger exists after the first order

Friction

 Evidence: 33% of respondents say they 'forgot to reorder / weren't prompted.' 0 follow-up nudges in app after order 1.

 "I genuinely forgot Zepto Cafe existed after my first order."

 **Impact on repeat rate: HIGH — without a cue, even satisfied users go silent. Competitive data: Swiggy reports 20–40% CTR lift from timed personalized nudges.**

F2

First-order quality disappointment kills intent to return

Friction

 Evidence: 73% cite inconsistent quality. Taste score 3.57/5 vs importance of 4.60/5 — the largest gap in the survey.

 "I tried it once, the chai was lukewarm and the samosa was soggy. Why would I order again?"

 **Impact on repeat rate: HIGH — a negative first experience immediately eliminates any habit loop before it can start.**

F3

Competitors already 'own' the snack-break moment

Friction

 Evidence: 73% cite nearby chai/snack stalls; 60% cite office canteen. These are existing daily habits with physical proximity as the trigger.

 "My office canteen is right downstairs — Zepto needs to give me a reason to pick it over that."

 **Impact on repeat rate: MEDIUM-HIGH — Zepto Cafe is asking users to break an existing routine. Without a stronger hook, inertia wins.**

F4

No reorder mechanism — users must restart from scratch

Friction

 Evidence: Competitive gap: 0 of 4 major competitors fail to surface a one-tap reorder for Cafe orders. Every ordering session requires full navigation.

 "I ordered twice, liked it the second time, but there's nothing in the app that makes me want to come back."

 **Impact on repeat rate: MEDIUM — friction compounds at ₹100 ticket size. At ₹400, you'll navigate. At ₹100, you'll grab a biscuit from your drawer instead.**

F5

No quality signal builds trust before reordering

Friction

 Evidence: No competitor in q-commerce snacks offers a real-time freshness promise. Zepto Cafe has no in-app prep time, freshness badge, or 'made fresh' indicator.

 "If there was something that reminded me to order chai around 4pm, I'd probably use it more often."

 **Impact on repeat rate: MEDIUM — trust is rebuilt order by order. With no freshness signal, users have no reason to give Zepto a second chance after a bad experience.**



3. The Primary Barrier — The Missing Habit Hook

While quality disappointment (F2) is the root cause of first-order failure, the product lever with the most direct impact on the 12% → 25% repeat rate target is:

PRIMARY BARRIER

Zepto Cafe creates no behavioural loop

after the first order. There is no cue, no routine, and no accumulating reward — so even users who had a positive experience have no reason to return.

3a. The Habit Loop Gap — Where Zepto Cafe Breaks Down

Using Nir Eyal's Hook Model and Duhigg's habit loop as a diagnostic framework:

Stage	❌ Zepto Cafe Today	✅ What Needs to Exist
 CUE (Trigger)	No trigger exists after order 1. App sits silent in user's phone. Snack-break moment passes with no nudge.	Time-of-day push at 3:45pm: 'Your usual chai — ready in 10 mins?' Contextual, personal, not generic.
 ROUTINE (Action)	User must open app, navigate to Cafe section, browse menu, rebuild cart from scratch. 60–90 second friction at ₹100 decision.	One-tap reorder: Favourite order surfaced on Cafe home screen. Order in under 15 seconds.
 REWARD (Outcome)	No accumulating reward. No visible progress. No sense of loyalty building. Every order feels like the first.	Visible streak or stamp progress ('3 of 9 chais — keep going!'). Reward feels earned, not gifted.
 INVESTMENT (Future pull)	User leaves nothing in the app. No saved preferences, no favourite items, no feedback loop that improves future orders.	Saved favourites, order history, freshness rating creates a 'this app knows me' feeling that deepens with use.

3b. Why the Habit Hook Is the Right Primary Lever (Not Quality Alone)

The PM reasoning

Quality (F2) is the root cause — but kitchen operations, food preparation and supply chain are explicitly OUT OF SCOPE.

The habit hook (F1) is fully within in-app experience scope — it is 100% buildable within Zepto Cafe's existing app.

Competitive proof: Zomato's Streak feature and Starbucks' Coffee Loop both drive 15–40% frequency lifts using engagement mechanics, not food quality improvements.

Sequencing insight: A habit hook works best when quality is at least adequate. Survey data shows 47% of users tried Zepto — some had okay experiences but still didn't return. The habit hook captures THIS segment immediately.

The quality gap is addressed in parallel through in-app trust signals (freshness badges, prep timestamps) — not kitchen operations.

"If there was something that reminded me to order chai around 4pm, I'd probably use it more often."

— Survey respondent, 29-year-old hybrid worker

"I ordered twice, liked it the second time, but there's nothing in the app that makes me want to come back."

— Survey respondent, 32-year-old office professional



4. Business Impact Analysis

What does the 12% → 25% gap cost Zepto Cafe today — and what is the opportunity?

4a. The Cost of a 12% Repeat Rate

What's Happening Now (12%)

- 100,000 daily Cafe orders baseline (case study)
- ~12,000 orders/day from repeat users (12%)
- 88% of first-time users never return
- CAC is wasted on 88% of acquired users
- No LTV accumulation for majority of user base

What 25% Repeat Rate Unlocks

- ~25,000 repeat orders/day — 108% more than today
- +13,000 incremental repeat orders per day
- At ₹100 avg AOV: ₹13 lakh additional GMV/day
- Annualised: ~₹47 crore incremental GMV/year
- Repeat users have 3–5x higher LTV than one-time users

4b. The Compounding Effect of Habit

Repeat ordering is not linear — it compounds. A user who reorders at day 10 is significantly more likely to order at day 20, and then daily. Blinkit and Swiggy's data shows that once a user reaches their 3rd order, their 30-day frequency jumps from ~1.2 to ~4.5 orders per month.

Order 1 → Order 2

The critical jump.

Only 12% make this.

This is where we lose 88%.

Order 2 → Order 3

The commitment point.

Users who reach order 3 are ~4x more likely to become monthly regulars.

Order 3+

The habit zone.

Ordering becomes automatic. Brand association forms. Churn rate drops sharply.

The PM implication

Getting a user from Order 1 to Order 2 is 10x harder than getting from Order 2 to Order 3.

Every product decision in Step 3 onwards must be evaluated by: 'Does this increase the probability of Order 2?'

A 13% absolute improvement (12%→25%) is actually a 108% increase in repeat order volume — the compounding effect means the business impact is non-linear.

4c. Strategic Stakes — Why This Is Urgent

- **Competitive window:** Swiggy Instamart is actively abandoning low-ticket snack users (AOV target ₹700+). This is a 6–12 month window where Zepto Cafe can own the office snack-break habit before anyone else moves in.
- **Unit economics:** Repeat users eliminate re-acquisition cost. At ₹100 AOV, every repeat order is structurally profitable vs. an acquired-via-discount first order.
- **Zepto Pass leverage:** Zepto already has 1M+ Zepto Pass subscribers. Extending habit hooks to Cafe within the existing app is a distribution advantage Swiggy and Zomato cannot replicate without a new product build.
- **Category creation:** No competitor currently owns 'fresh, hot snack in 10 minutes as a daily office ritual.' This is Zepto Cafe's to win — if it solves retention.



5. Problem Statement — Grounded in Research

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Office snack-break users try Zepto Cafe (47% have ordered at least once), but only 12% return within 30 days — not because Zepto is too slow (speed scores 4.57/5), but because there is no behavioural trigger, no reorder shortcut, and no accumulating reward that makes a second order feel natural.

The result: Zepto acquires a user, delivers the order, and then goes completely silent — leaving the user with no reason, reminder, or pull to return. The office canteen and the chai stall win by default — not because they're better, but because they're already wired into the user's daily routine.

Problem Statement in Jobs-to-be-Done Format

When	I'm at my office desk at 3:30–4:30pm and feel the mid-afternoon hunger / chai craving
I want to	Order a fresh chai and snack quickly, without leaving my desk or thinking too hard about it
So I can	Satisfy my craving, get back to work, and feel like I made a smart, convenient choice

But today

I default to the canteen or chai stall because Zepto Cafe doesn't remind me, doesn't make it effortless to reorder, and gave me a lukewarm chai last time — so it never became my routine

 6. Summary — What Step 3 Must Solve For

What We Are NOT Solving (Step 3)	What Step 3 Solutions Must Address
 Kitchen operations or food prep quality (out of scope)  Delivery partner speed (already a strength at 4.57/5)  Discount-led retention (constraint: no discount-only strategy)  Full Zepto grocery redesign (out of scope)	 Create a behavioural cue at snack-break time (3:30–4:30pm)  Reduce reorder friction to under 15 seconds  Build an accumulating reward that makes habit feel worth forming  Signal freshness / quality to rebuild trust without changing kitchen ops